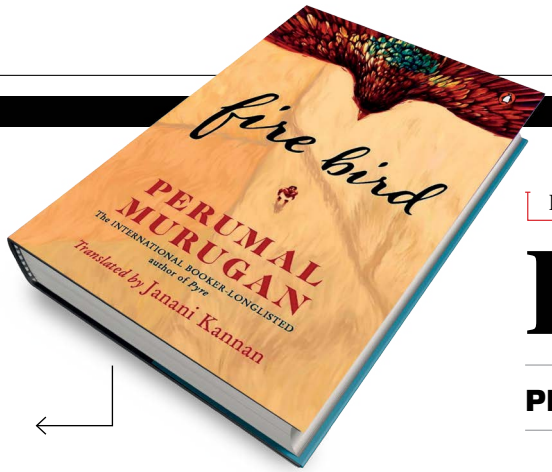


FIRE BIRD
by Perumal Murugan (translated by Janani Kannan)
PENGUIN
₹**499; 304** pages

BOOKS

In Search o

PERUMAL MURUGAN'S AGRARIAN PERIOD

The 2023 JCB Prize for Literature was awarded to Perumal Murugan's *Aalandapatchi*, translated into English as *Fire Bird* by Janani Kannan. The prize money of Rs 25 lakh will be split between author and translator. Murugan had previously been shortlisted in 2018 (for the novel *Poonachi*, translated by N. Kalyan Raman) and 2019 (for the novels *A Lonely Harvest* and *Trial by Silence*, both translated by Aniruddhan Vasudevan). While Murugan was not present in New Delhi for the award ceremony, he sent a video address acknowledging the recognition.

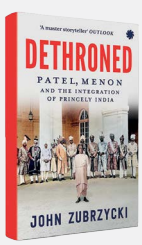
Talking about *Fire Bird*, Murugan said in his address, "Who among us doesn't want to live in one place forever? And yet, migration isn't over. There are a number of compulsions that explain why humans migrate: climate change, politics, finding work. This novel is based on the forced migration of an agrarian family six decades ago. It's also informed by the stories of migration from my own family that I have witnessed firsthand. This novel is about the tragedy of being displaced from one's own land and one's family."

Set in the Kongunadu region of Tamil Nadu in the 1940s onwards, *Fire Bird* is a deceptively straightforward story—through the story of the displaced farmer Muthu and his wife Peruma, Murugan weaves in a lot of interconnected themes that contribute to the central story arc about migration. We see how the changing socio-economic nature of the region forces people to change their agricultural practices. Because Muthu's forced migration happens after a family feud pertaining to land, we see how ingrained feudal practices are among the characters. Finally, Muthu's equa-

BOOKS

UNITING INDIA

JOHN ZUBRZYCKI'S *DETHRONED* IS A COMPELLING NARRATION OF THE INTEGRATION OF THE PRINCELY STATES INTO THE INDIAN UNION



DETHRONED
Patel, Menon and the Integration of Princely India
by John Zubrzycki
JUGGERNAUT
₹**799; 360** pages

The story of the integration of the Indian princely states is well known, but John Zubrzycki in retelling it adds animation with flesh and blood to make this book a compelling read.

In retrospect, the integration appears almost automatic—in a sense a parallel and linear process alongside the freedom struggle. In fact, it was often precarious and contingent—especially so in the case of the larger princely states which, and not just on paper, had some claim to viability as independent countries. The dangers of a major Balkanisation in 1947 may appear remote today, but it was a real possibility. That the entire process was completed more or less smoothly, with the significant exception of Kashmir, Hyderabad and Junagadh, is testimony to the efforts of Patel and V.P. Menon—an achievement made even greater by the fact that it took place amidst a communal bloodbath and a division of the State itself.

Some states were outliers in this process, in particular, Hyderabad and Junagadh, both Hindu majority with Muslim rulers; and Kashmir, Muslim majority with a Hindu ruler. Zubrzycki devotes a chapter to each. Here military means—with enormous collateral damage in the case of Hyderabad—proved unavoidable and the story of their merger was to become indistinguishable from the larger one of India-Pakistan recrimination and conflict. Kalat provides the counterpart case in Pakistan, and here, too, the shadows cast by its accession extend into our own times as in the case of Kashmir.

A merit of this book is that it continues the story beyond the drama of the formal integration. The next step was the merger of most of these princedoms into administratively viable units. This was technically a breach of the promise made to their princes that their internal affairs would not be interfered with. Here again, a combination of financial inducement in the form of a tax-free privy purse and retention of titles and certain privileges alongside not-so-gentle threats was employed. By the end of 1949, only three—Mysore, Hyderabad and Kashmir—of the original nearly 550 states that had acceded to India remained as independent administrative units. Again, a major achievement, not least because it was carried out expeditiously at a testing time for the country.

Dethroned also relates the final act of this saga—the abolition of privy purses and princely privileges by a Constitutional amendment, which rendered India's former princes defunct. If their individual fates lead to nostalgia for few today, that is as good a reason as any to show how much their age has passed. This book makes the process of how it came to pass accessible, in a riveting and engrossing read. ■

T.C.A. Raghavan